

ENGLISH LANGUAGE PAPER 4

PART A Group Interaction

This article appeared in a newspaper in Hong Kong:

Bike-sharing services push off in Hong Kong

Smart.bike, a start-up founded by Peter Wong two months ago, aims to offer busy people an easy option for short distance commutes. The service works by allowing cyclists to rent and drop off bicycles around Hong Kong.

"We are here to make transportation convenient and affordable," he said. A ride on a Smart bike will cost HK\$5 per half hour. Currently, bike rentals for leisure purposes cost HK\$40 per day in Tai Po.

Wong said that there was a great demand for bike-sharing in a city like Hong Kong, where people walk considerable distances between public transport stops. Bicycles certainly fill this gap.

To rent a Smart bike, which is powered by solar panels, users will need to log into a mobile application, register their credit card and pay a deposit of HK\$399. An active map will locate the nearest bicycle.

The company has 400 bikes at present. The number is expected to reach 1,000 by the end of the week, and 20,000 by July.

Unlike existing bike rental services in Hong Kong, cyclists riding Smart bikes will not have to pick up and drop off their bicycles at fixed locations.

"You can park them anywhere as long as it is legal," Wong said, referring to public cycle parking spaces across the city.

He said the service could also be a solution for people who had very limited living space to store their own bikes.

Your economics teacher wants you to discuss businesses which offer sharing services. You may want to talk about:

- the advantages of bike-sharing services
- the problems of bike-sharing services and possible solutions
- other sharing services that could be introduced in Hong Kong
- anything else you think is important

PART B Individual Response

1. Do you ever go cycling?
2. How did you learn to ride a bike?
3. Would you use a bike-sharing service?
4. Why can cycling in Hong Kong be dangerous?
5. Would you prefer to cycle to school or take public transport?
6. What can the government do to improve safety for cyclists?
7. Do you think car-sharing would be successful?
8. Will there be more sharing services in the future?